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ALFRED

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CASSIDI

View banking market concentrations and perform HHI analysis.

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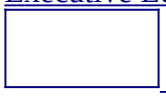
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Thirty Years of Web Archiving Show Our Public Information Efforts

November 04, 2026
By Pamela Campbell
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Every website tells a story — not just through its content, but through its evolution. The St. Louis Fed's website tells the story of one of our long-standing priorities: making economic information available and accessible to everyone.

But how do we access that story, when digital content is continually changing? That's where archiving comes in. For 30 years, snapshots of our websites have been building in the public record, each one a small act of preservation. That we can trace a digital story back that long is thanks to deliberate preservation work at institutions like the Internet Archive, the Library of Congress and, increasingly, our own Bank.

From Mailroom to Modem

Even before the web, the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis was a pioneer in the distribution of economic information to the public. It started small. In 1961, Research Director Homer Jones began mailing economic data to subscribers, a practice that would, decades later, evolve into tools like FRED, FRASER and ALFRED. As the introduction to a timeline of "FRED and Friends" developments says, "This commitment to universal data access and data literacy is built on the premise that a better-informed public

helps maintain the stability of the financial system and the economy as a whole."

As the technology landscape changed dramatically in the 1990s, how we distributed information changed as well. The World Wide Web went "public" in 1993, and the St. Louis Fed was an early adopter, launching our first website in September 1995 at www.stls.frb.org.

A 1995 presentation about the launch of the website said: "Our primary goal was to make the Research Division's economic database, FRED available on the internet. We created a home page for the Bank with some brief information about the Federal Reserve System and our Bank. Then proceeded to spend most of our time getting FRED set up."

A primary goal of launching the St. Louis Fed's website in 1995 was to make economic database FRED available on the internet, according to a presentation from that year.

Alongside FRED, our early website included: general information on the St. Louis Fed; community profiles, which featured regional economic data for several cities in the Eighth Federal Reserve District; and information on other internet sites.

Building Out Our Web Presence

The St. Louis Fed site grew steadily through the late '90s, but 2002 marked a bigger shift. We moved from our original address at www.stls.frb.org to our current address, www.stlouisfed.org. At the same time, "FRED II" launched as a new, enhanced version of FRED offering additional download formats as well as charting capabilities. "FRED II" (or "FRED2") ran alongside FRED until the original database was discontinued in July 2003. Within two years, FRED2 became "FRED."

From there, the Bank's public economic information tools multiplied:

- FRASER, our digital library of historical economic documents, launched in 2004.
- ALFRED launched in 2006, letting users see what economic data looked like before later revisions.
- CASSIDI also launched in 2006, giving bankers and analysts tools for competitive market analysis.

The St. Louis Fed website underwent a redesign and moved to the stlouisfed.org address in 2002.

Beyond data tools, the Bank's growing body of research publications, educational resources, financial service information and community development content was finding its own home online, expanding the effort beyond numbers and charts to include analysis, teaching tools and outreach. The website had evolved into an important public hub for making complex information transparent, accessible and usable.

How we share information has continued to evolve with technology:

- Mobile apps brought FRED data into people's pockets.
- Social media gave the Bank new ways to share research and insights and reach new audiences.
- Video has become an increasingly important part of the effort, offering a more engaging way to explain economic concepts, share research and bring the Bank's message to broader audiences.

The St. Louis Fed’s website in 2014.

Looking Back, Looking Ahead

Looking back through 30 years, what stands out isn’t what has changed, but what has stayed the same. Long before “digital transparency” was a buzzword, we were mailing data and building websites. Whatever form our website takes next, from AI-driven tools to platforms we haven’t imagined yet, we’ll continue to put economic information within reach of the people we serve.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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